Crossing the Bridge

50 Exercises for Clarinet over the Break

Chromatic · Seconds · Thirds · Intervals · Arpeggios · Patterns · Études

All music at written pitch (B♭ or A clarinet)

About this book

The “break” or “bridge” is the move between the throat register (written G4–B♭4, the notes around and above the middle line of the treble staff) and the clarion register, starting at written B4 on the middle line. Going from a throat tone with almost no fingers down to a clarion note with nearly every hole covered and the register key open asks the whole hand to move at once. These exercises concentrate on exactly that crossing, in every common key and pattern.

How to practise

- **Slow first.** Start each exercise at ♩ = 60 or slower. Raise the metronome only when the crossing is clean and even three times running.
- **Right hand down.** On the throat tones (G, G♯, A, B♭), keep the right-hand fingers down. Most notes keep their pitch, often sound better, and the clarion note then needs only the left hand and thumb.
- **Roll the thumb.** Keep the left thumb touching the register key and tilt it open; don’t lift it away and come back.
- **Fingers together.** Uneven fingers cause the squeak or “blip” in the middle of a crossing. Move all fingers as one gesture, close to the keys.
- **Air leads, not lips.** Keep the air fast and the voicing high and steady across the break; don’t bite on the clarion notes.
- **Articulation variants.** Play each exercise slurred (as marked), then fully tongued, then slur-two / tongue-two, then tongue-one / slur-three.
- **Rhythm variants.** For running eighths, also try dotted rhythms (long–short and short–long) to drill the crossing at both speeds.
- **Transpose.** The scale and pattern exercises can be played in any key; once comfortable, work through all twelve.
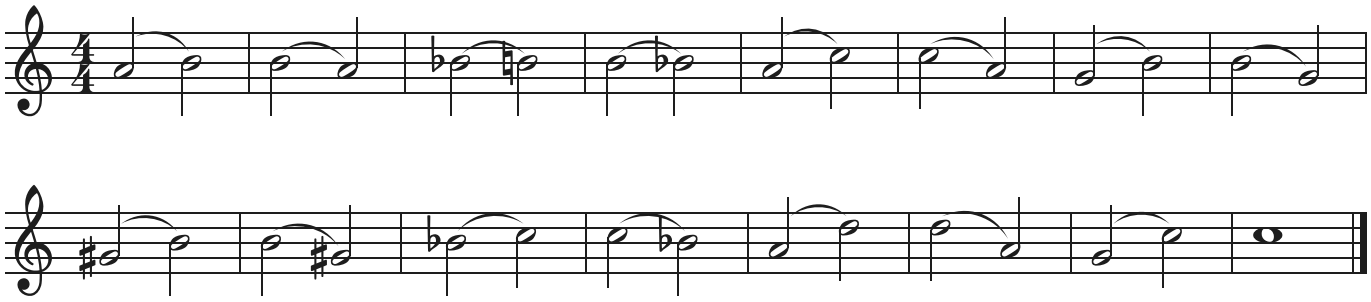
Contents

I. Foundations	Nos. 1–6
II. Chromatic	Nos. 7–12
III. Scales in seconds	Nos. 13–20
IV. Thirds	Nos. 21–26
V. Harmonic minor	Nos. 27–30
VI. Patterns	Nos. 31–44
VII. Symmetric scales	Nos. 45–46
VIII. Études	Nos. 47–50

I. Foundations

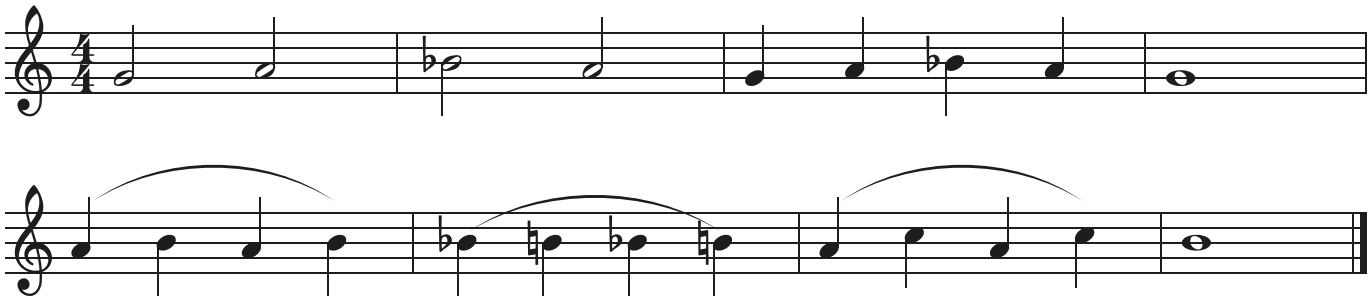
1. Long-tone slurs across the break

Half notes, ♩ = 60. Slur each pair without a gap. Keep the air fast and the voicing (tongue position) high on the throat note so the clarion note pops out without a bump. Right-hand fingers stay down on the throat tones.



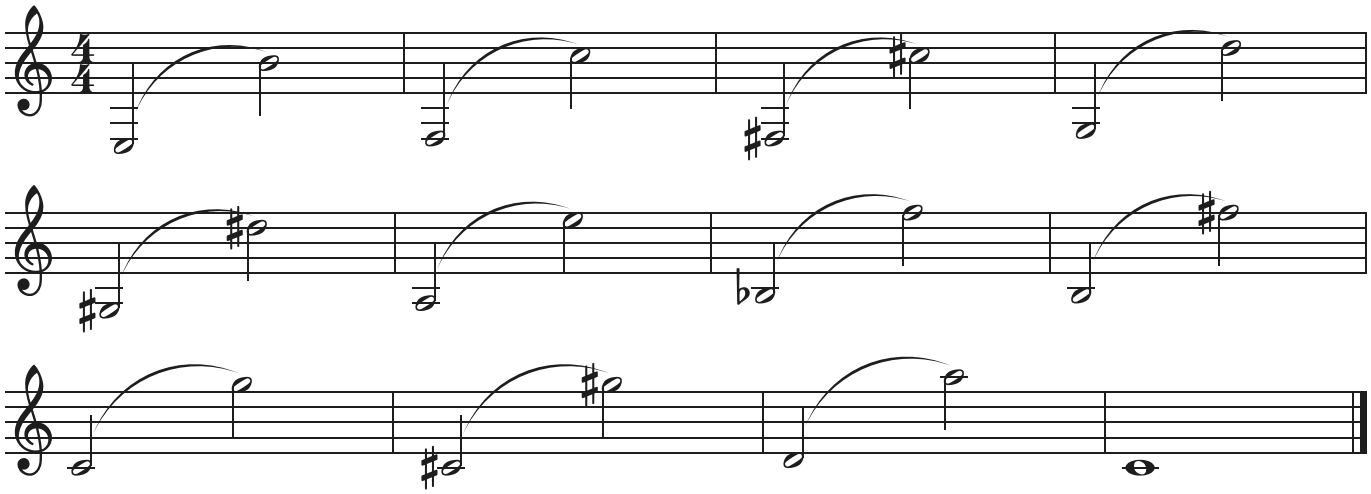
2. Right hand down: throat tones

Play the throat tones with all three right-hand fingers (and the little finger on the low B/C key if comfortable) held down. Pitch and tone usually improve, and the clarion note is then only a left-hand move away. Compare one bar 'hands off', one bar 'right hand down'.
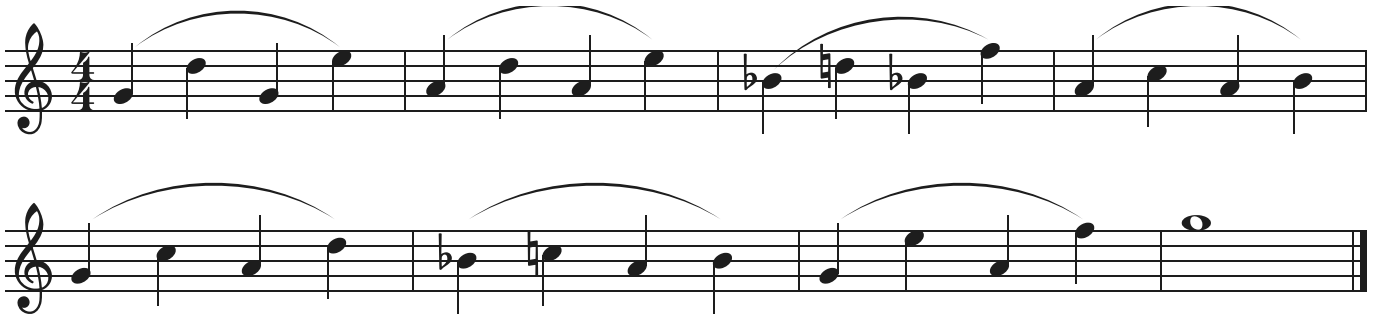


3. Twelfths: chalumeau to clarion

Finger the low note, add the register key, and the instrument jumps a twelfth into the clarion. Slur each pair; the low note should not change shape or embouchure when the thumb opens the register key. This trains the air support every bridge crossing needs.



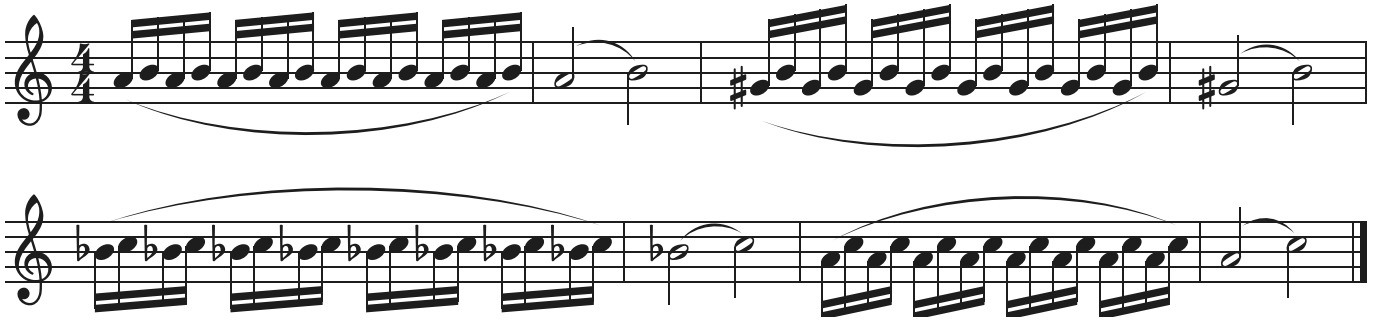
4. Leaps from the throat into the clarion

Quarter notes, slurred. Each leap starts on a throat tone and lands on a clarion note. Aim for the top note with air, not jaw pressure.
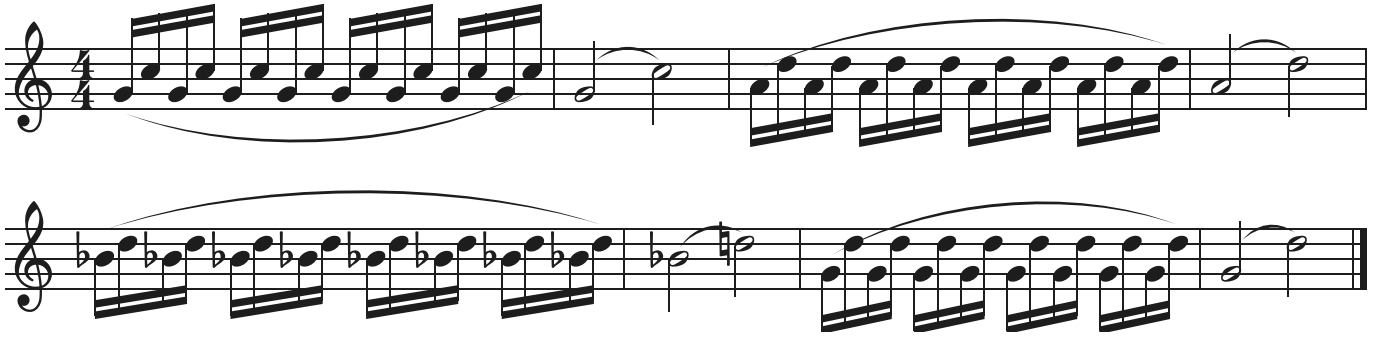


5. Bridge tremolos I

Sixteenth notes, start ♩ = 50. Alternate across the break as evenly as possible. Move all fingers together; listen for any 'blip' between the notes.



6. Bridge tremolos II
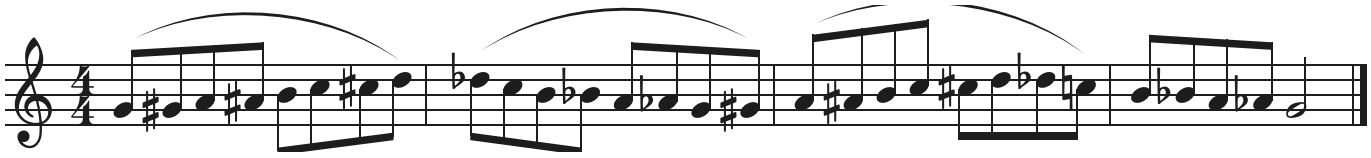
Wider tremolos. The throat note's right hand stays down throughout, so only the left hand and thumb move.



II. Chromatic
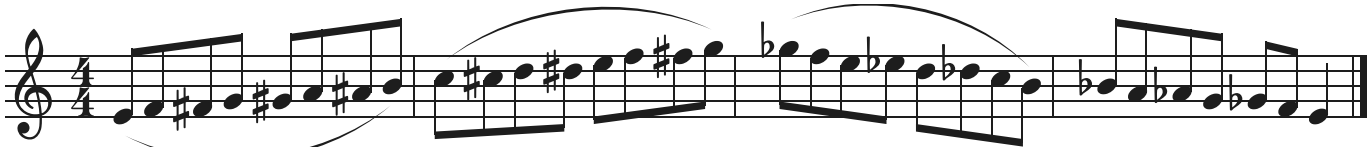
7. Chromatic: G4 to D5

Eighth notes, slurred, ♩ = 60 → 120. The core of the bridge. Use the right-hand side key for B♭/A♯ only if your teacher prefers; otherwise use the standard throat fingering with the right hand down.



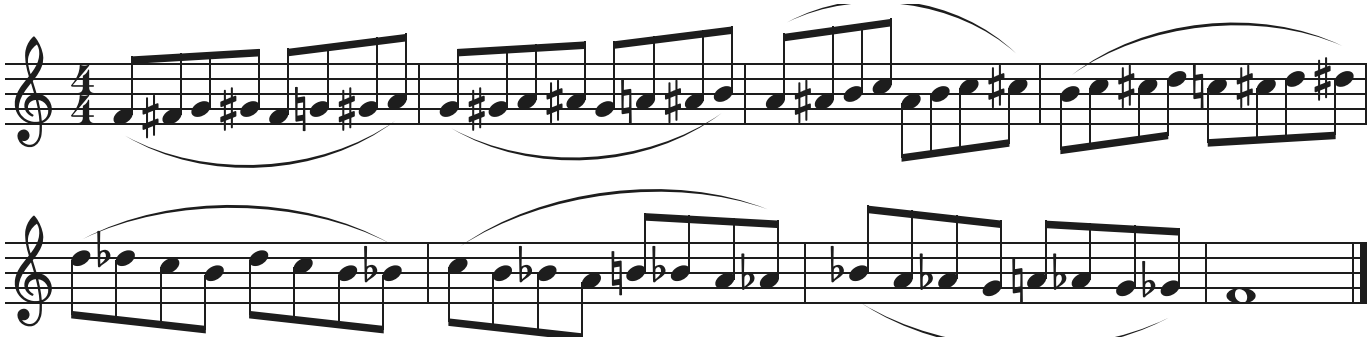
8. Chromatic: E4 to G5

A wider chromatic sweep. Keep the tone the same colour from the bottom to the top; the break should be invisible.



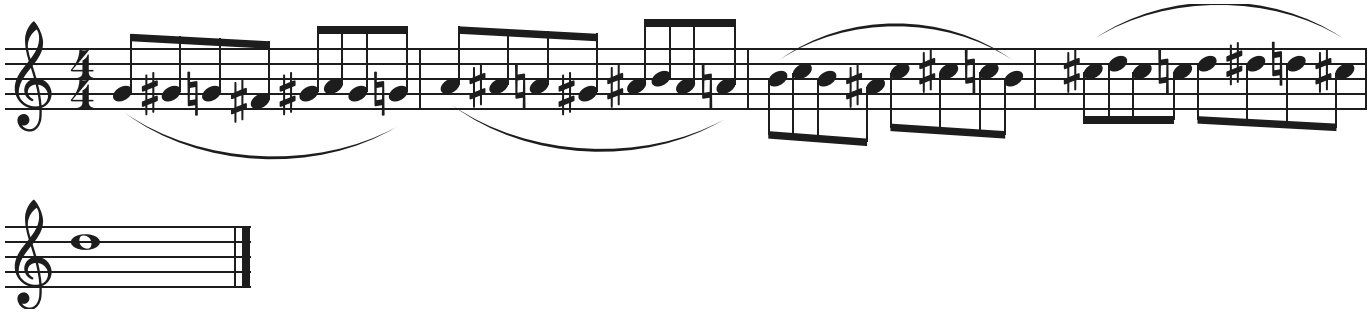
9. Chromatic groups of four

Each group of four starts a half step higher, then a half step lower on the way down. Slur in groups of four, then all tongued.



10. Chromatic neighbour notes

Upper and lower chromatic neighbours around every note of the bridge. Many of these cross the break twice per beat.



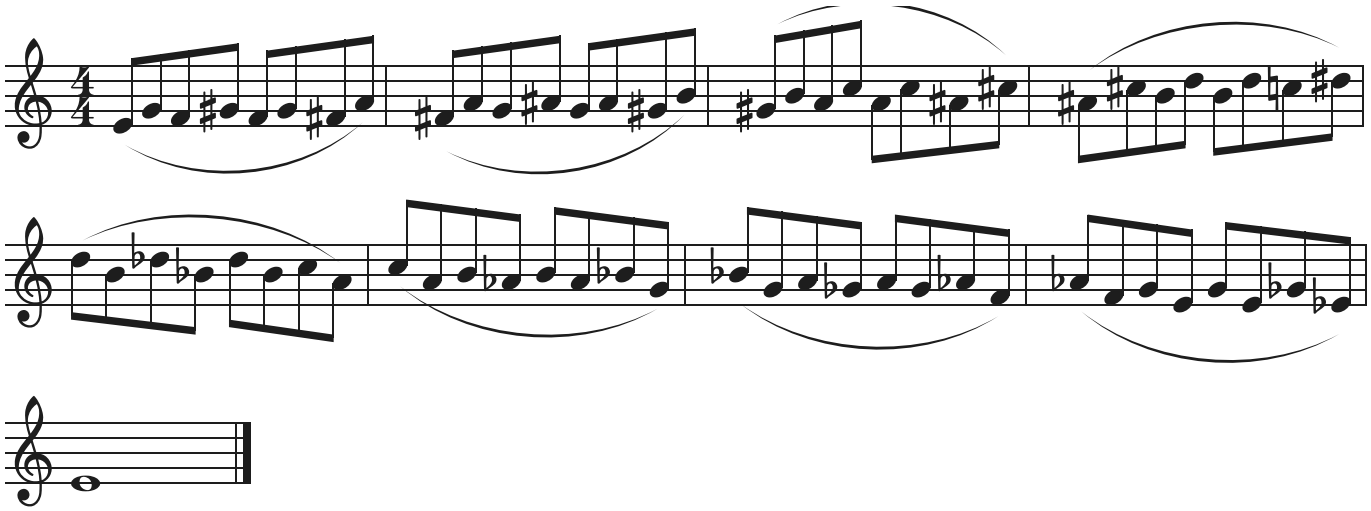
11. Chromatic triplets

Compound meter, three notes per beat. Accent the first of each group lightly so the groupings fall in different places on the instrument.



12. Chromatic minor thirds

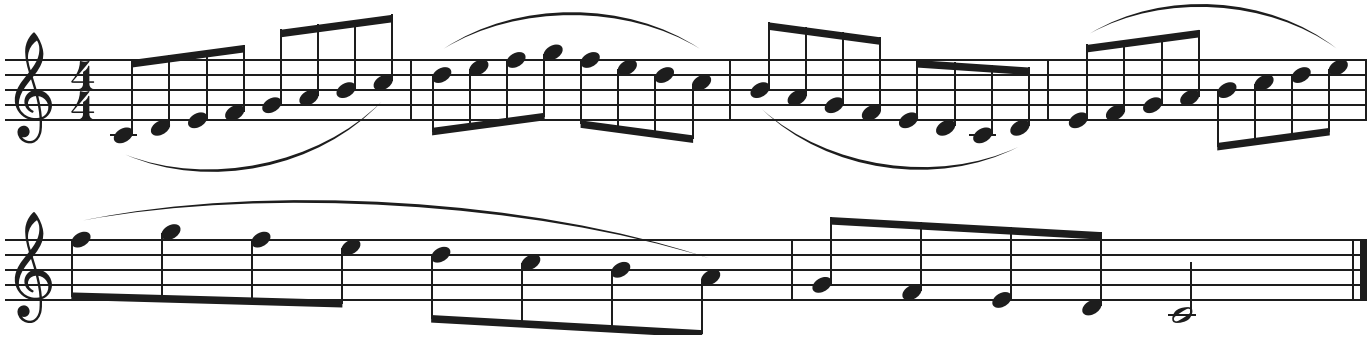
Pairs of minor thirds rising by half steps. A demanding finger-coordination drill: go slowly.



III. Scales in seconds

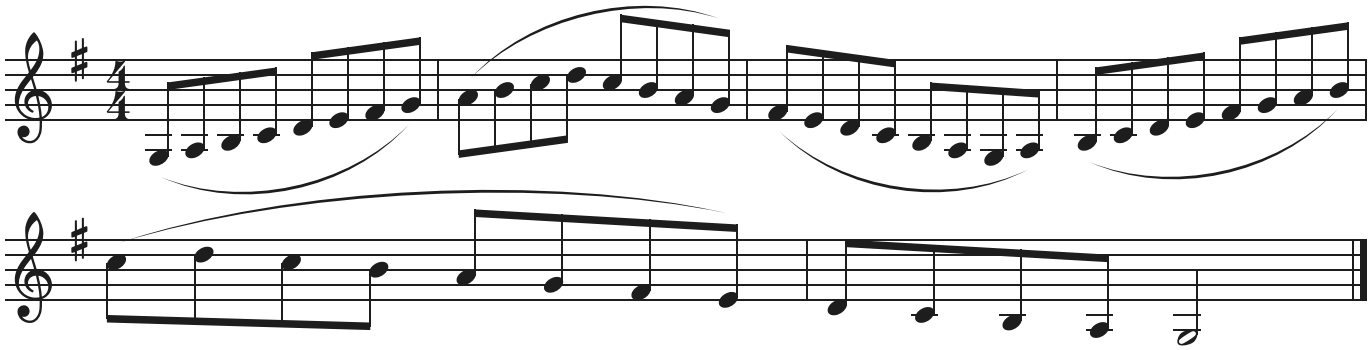
13. C major scale over the break

Two times through, slurred; then tongued. Hold the top and bottom notes steady in pitch. ♩ = 60 → 132.



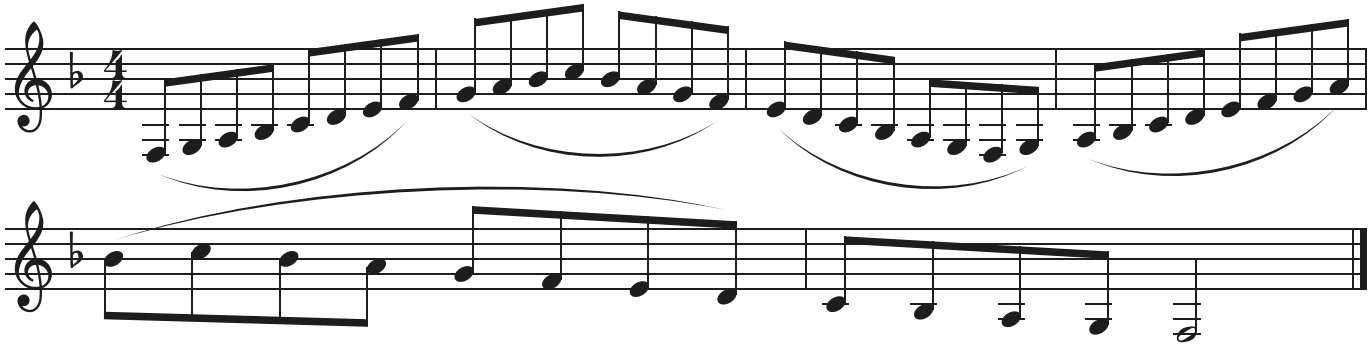
14. G major scale over the break

Two times through, slurred; then tongued. Hold the top and bottom notes steady in pitch. ♩ = 60 → 132.



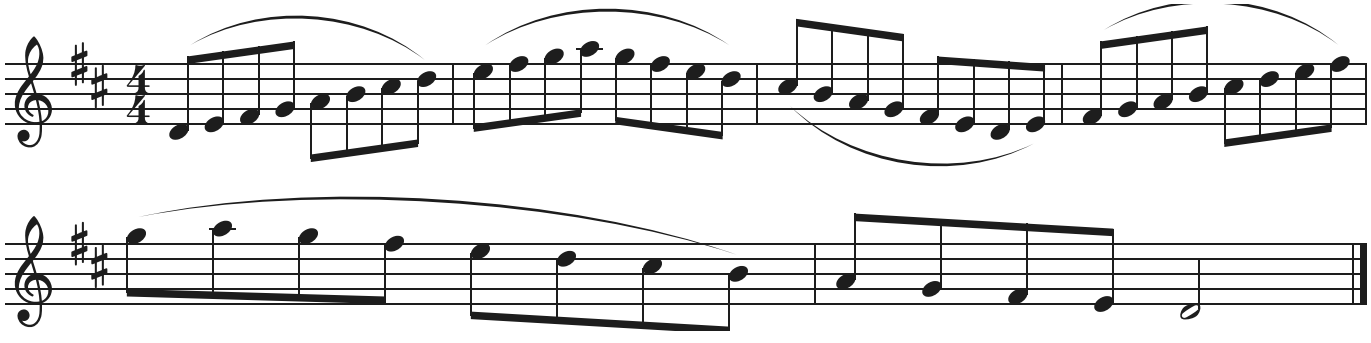
15. F major scale over the break

Two times through, slurred; then tongued. Hold the top and bottom notes steady in pitch. ♩ = 60 → 132.



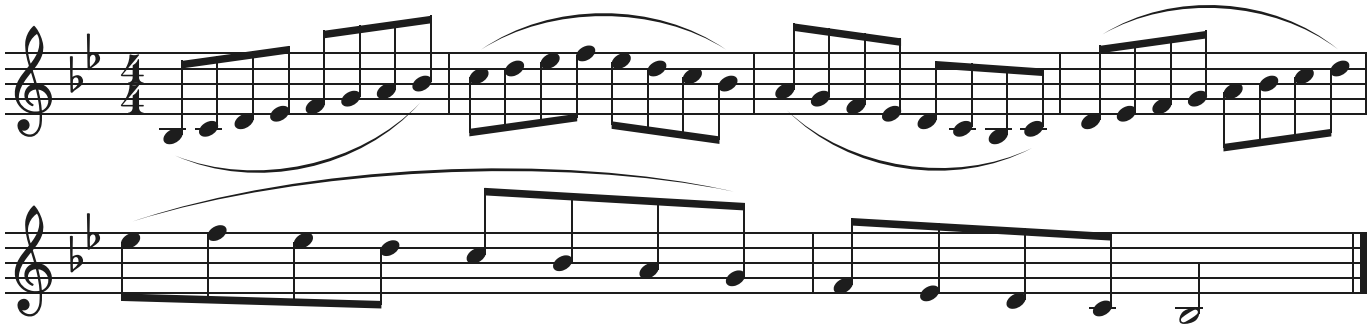
16. D major scale over the break

Two times through, slurred; then tongued. Hold the top and bottom notes steady in pitch. ♩ = 60 → 132.



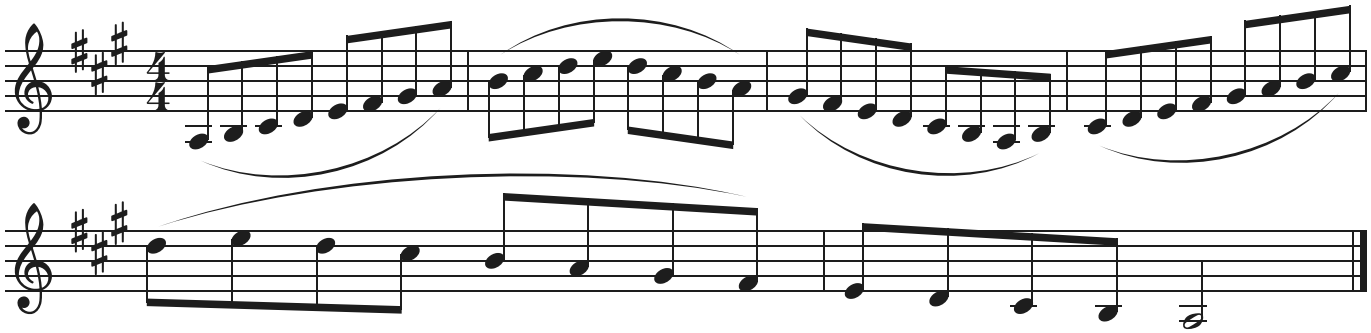
17. B♭ major scale over the break

Two times through, slurred; then tongued. Hold the top and bottom notes steady in pitch. ♩ = 60 → 132.



18. A major scale over the break

Two times through, slurred; then tongued. Hold the top and bottom notes steady in pitch. ♩ = 60 → 132.



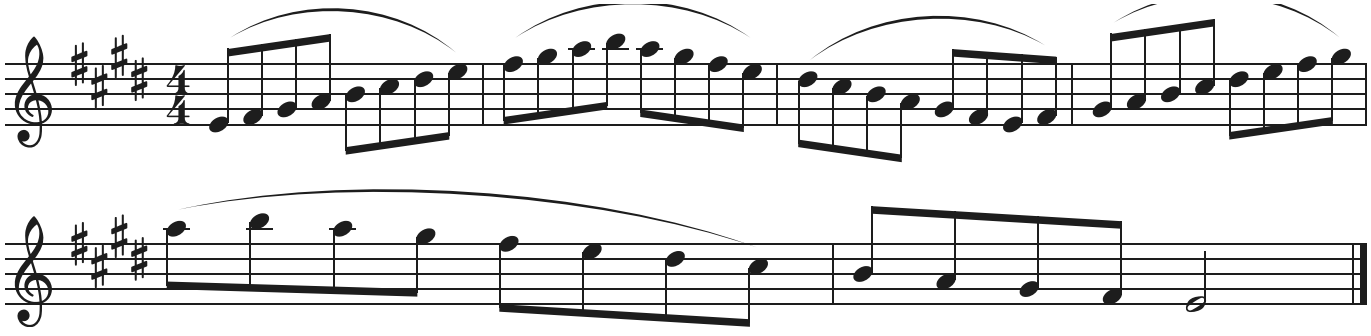
19. E♭ major scale over the break

Two times through, slurred; then tongued. Hold the top and bottom notes steady in pitch. ♩ = 60 → 132.



20. E major scale over the break

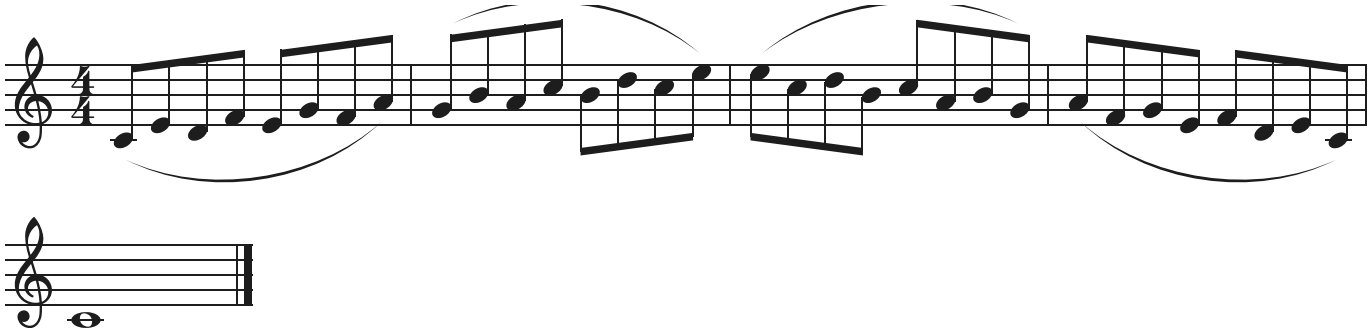
Two times through, slurred; then tongued. Hold the top and bottom notes steady in pitch. ♩ = 60 → 132.



IV. Thirds

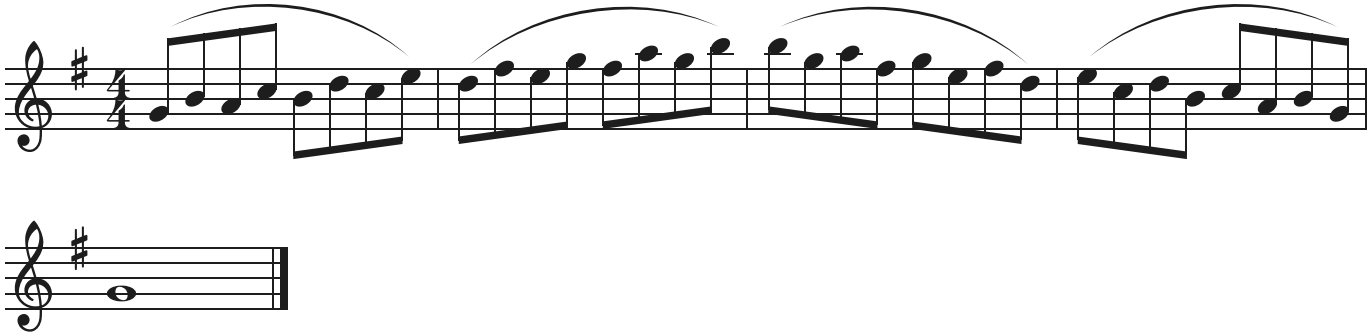
21. Thirds in C major

Broken thirds up and down. Many pairs straddle the break: make each pair a single gesture.



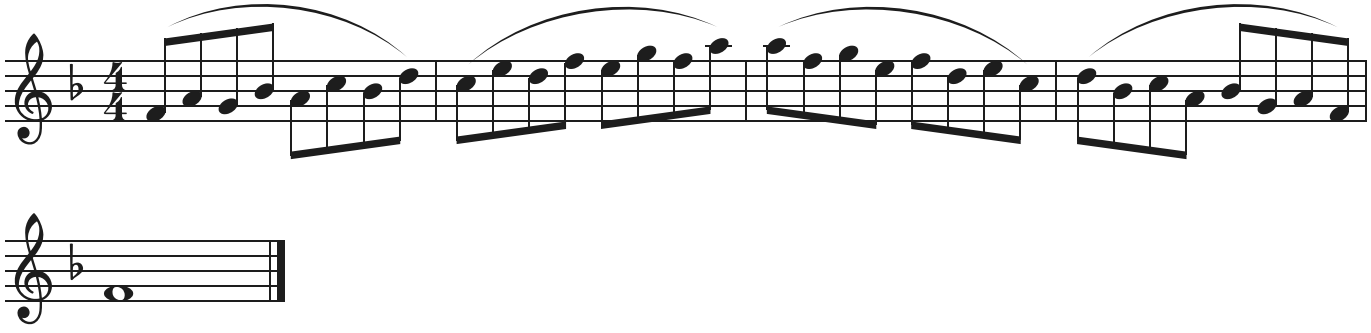
22. Thirds in G major

Broken thirds up and down. Many pairs straddle the break: make each pair a single gesture.



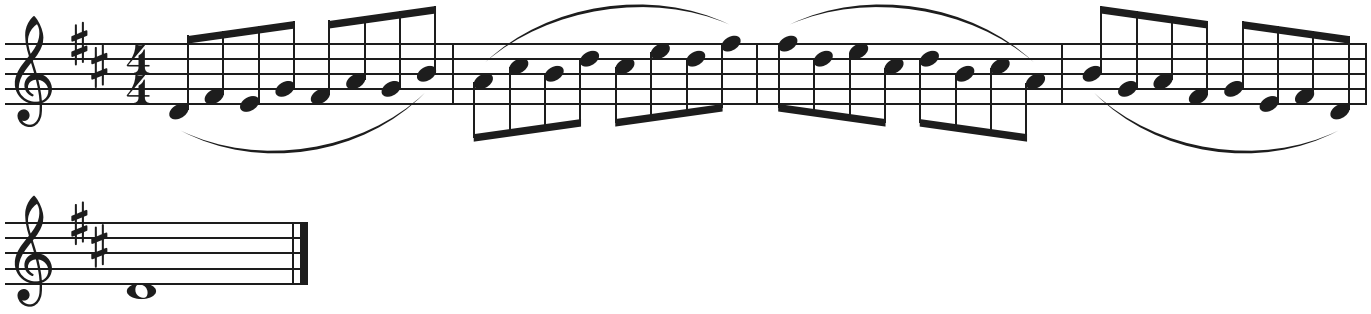
23. Thirds in F major

Broken thirds up and down. Many pairs straddle the break: make each pair a single gesture.



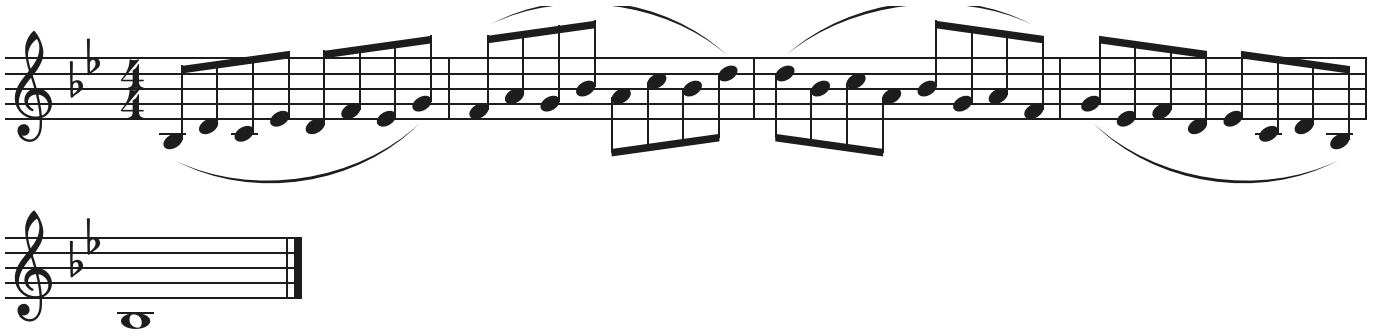
24. Thirds in D major

Broken thirds up and down. Many pairs straddle the break: make each pair a single gesture.



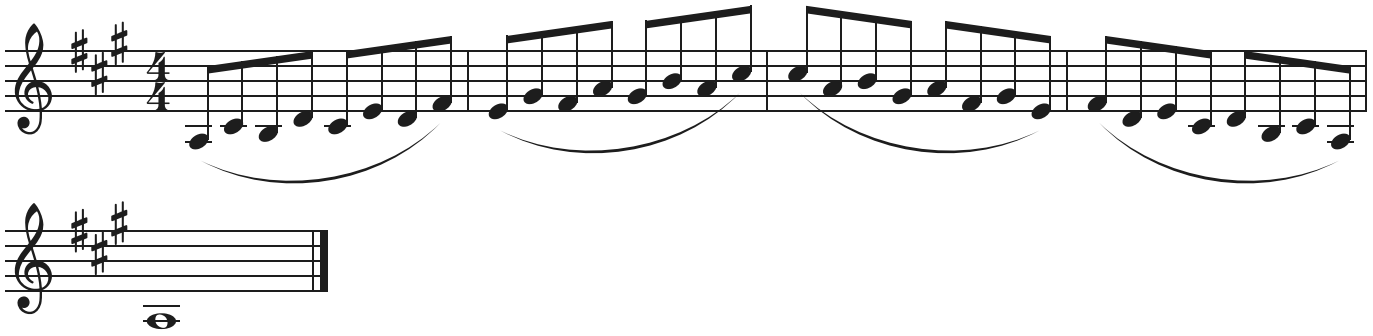
25. Thirds in B♭ major

Broken thirds up and down. Many pairs straddle the break: make each pair a single gesture.



26. Thirds in A major

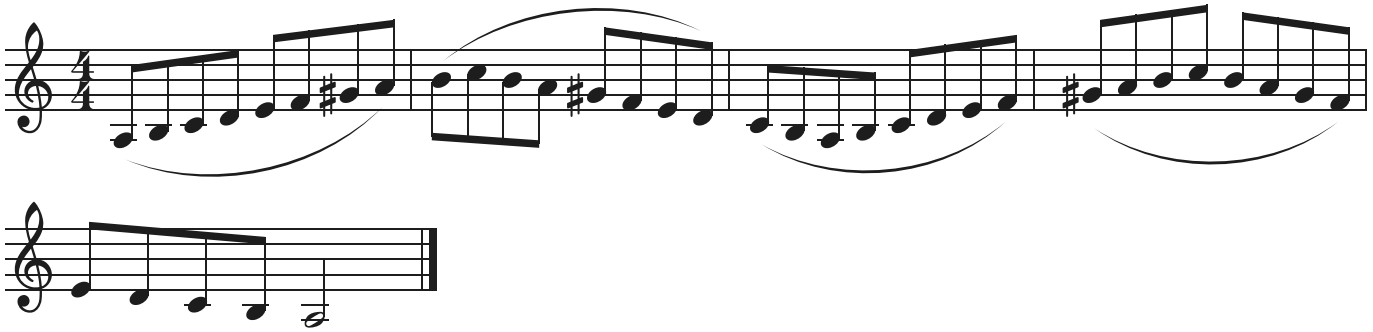
Broken thirds up and down. Many pairs straddle the break: make each pair a single gesture.



V. Harmonic minor

27. A harmonic minor

The raised seventh adds an awkward augmented second; several fall right at the break.



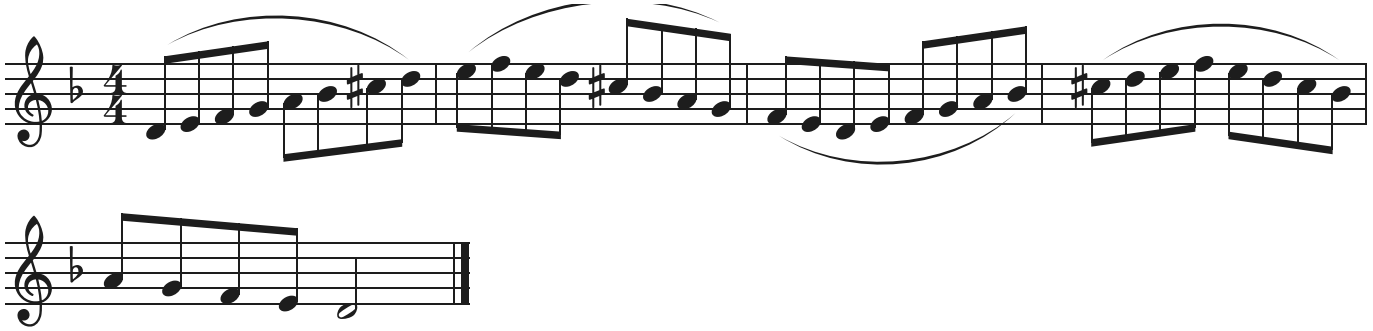
28. E harmonic minor

The raised seventh adds an awkward augmented second; several fall right at the break.



29. D harmonic minor

The raised seventh adds an awkward augmented second; several fall right at the break.



30. G harmonic minor

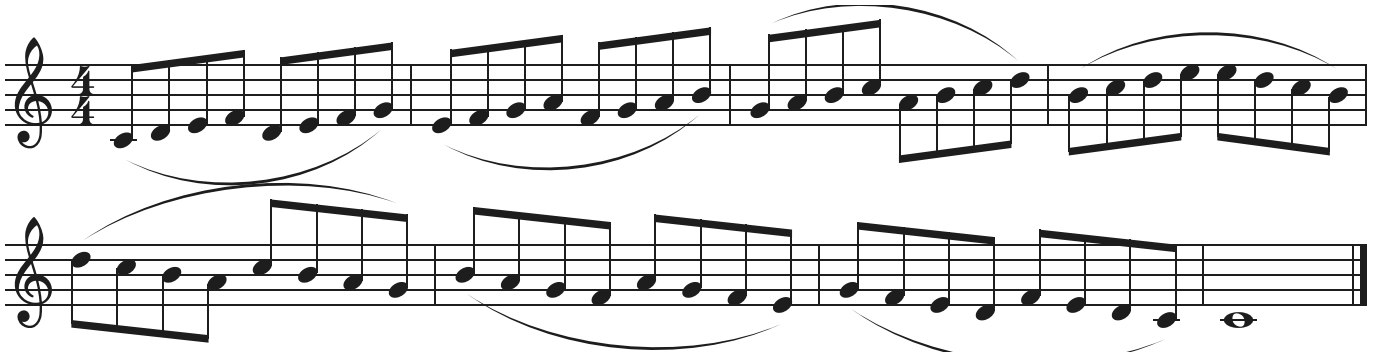
The raised seventh adds an awkward augmented second; several fall right at the break.



VI. Patterns
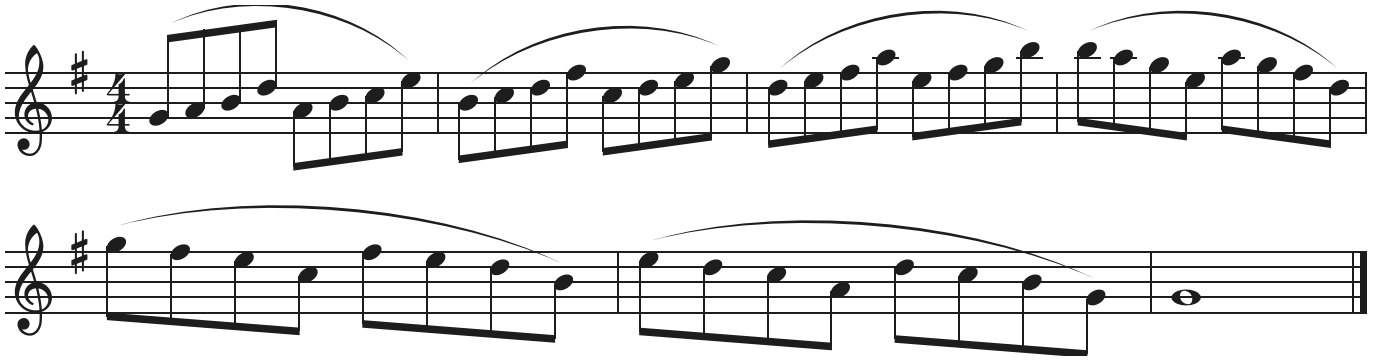
31. 1-2-3-4 in C major

Four-note scale groups, each starting one step higher.



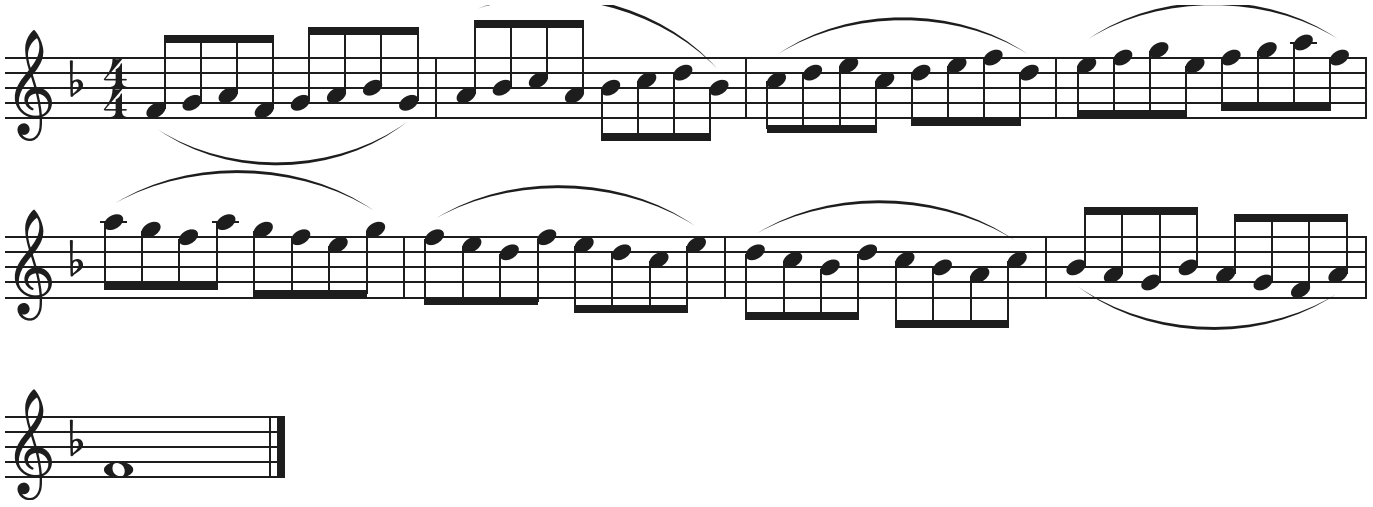
32. 1-2-3-5 in G major

A classic pattern; the skip at the end of each group often lands across the break.



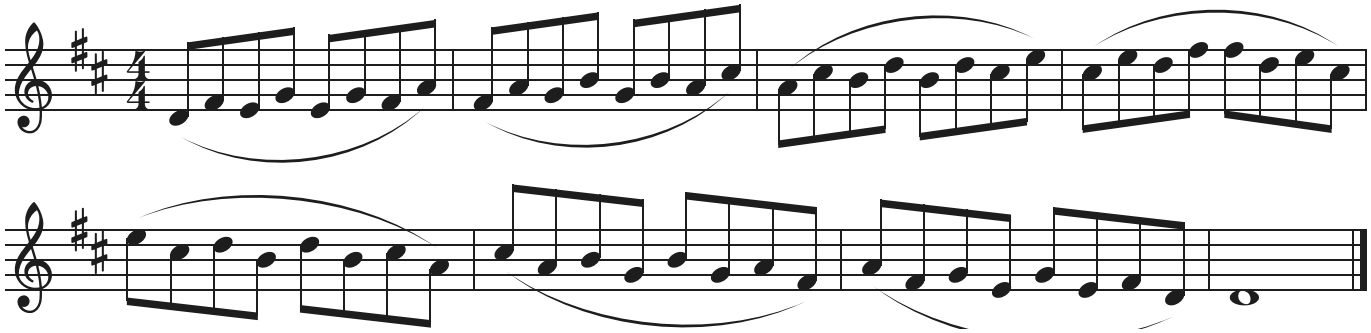
33. 1-2-3-1 in F major

Each group returns to its starting note. Watch the B♭–C–A and similar groups.



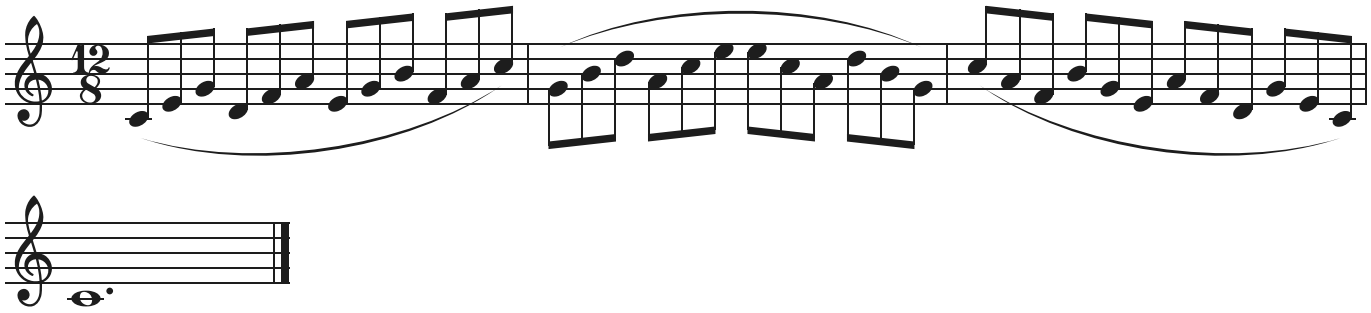
34. 1-3-2-4 in D major

Broken thirds inside a four-note group.



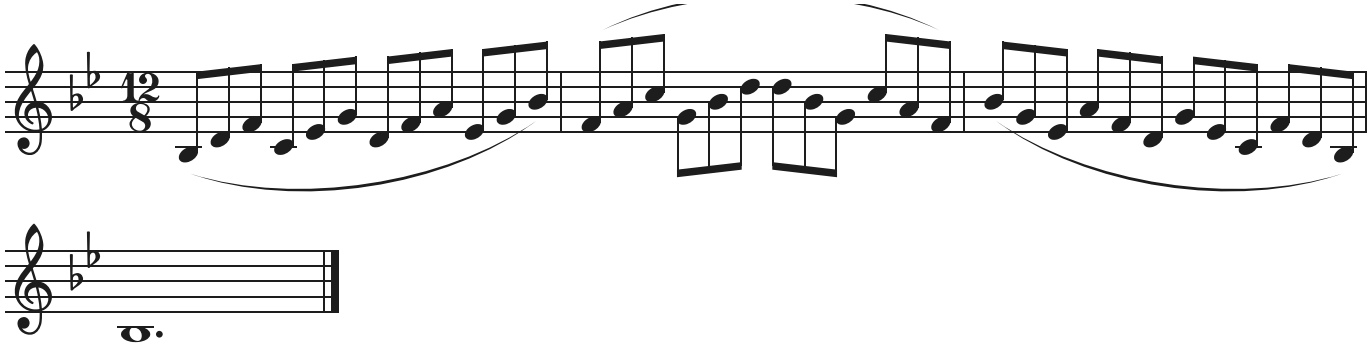
35. Triads on every degree in C

Compound meter. Each triad crosses the break at least once in the middle of the range.



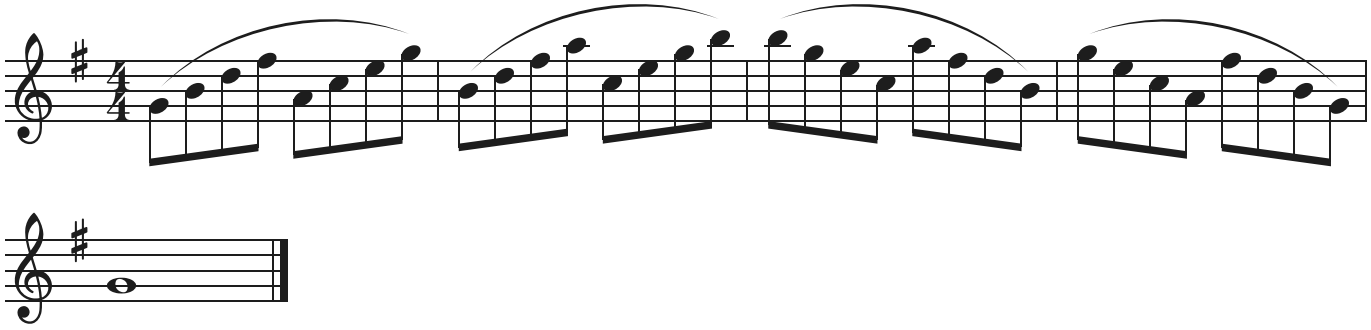
36. Triads on every degree in B♭

As above, in B♭ — the throat B♭ to clarion C/D is the hard spot.



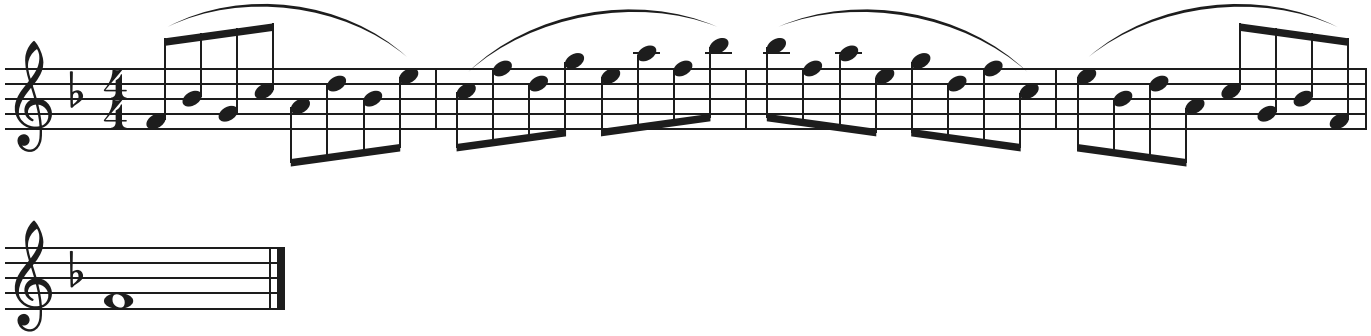
37. Seventh chords in G major

Four-note arpeggios on each degree. Keep fingers close to the keys.



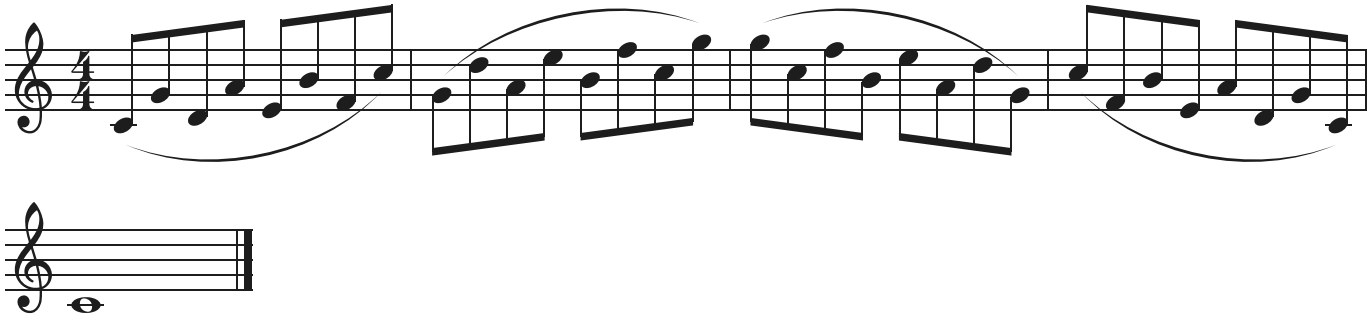
38. Fourths in F major

Broken fourths. Every pair should sound as smooth as a step.



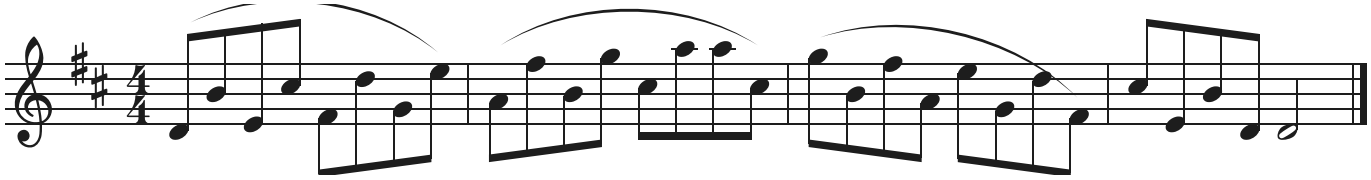
39. Fifths in C major

Broken fifths: a bigger leap means more air, not more lip.



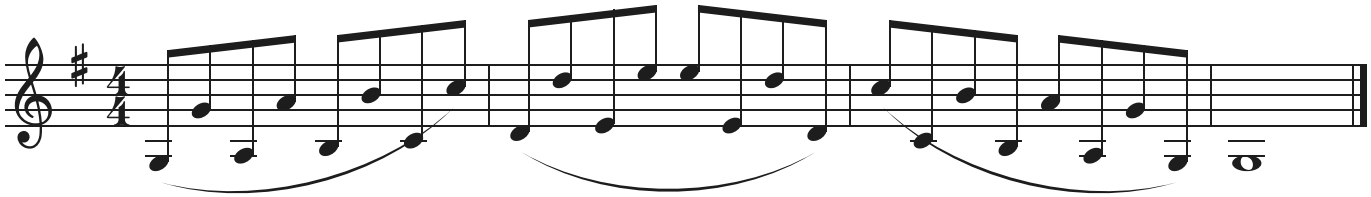
40. Sixths in D major

Broken sixths up and down.



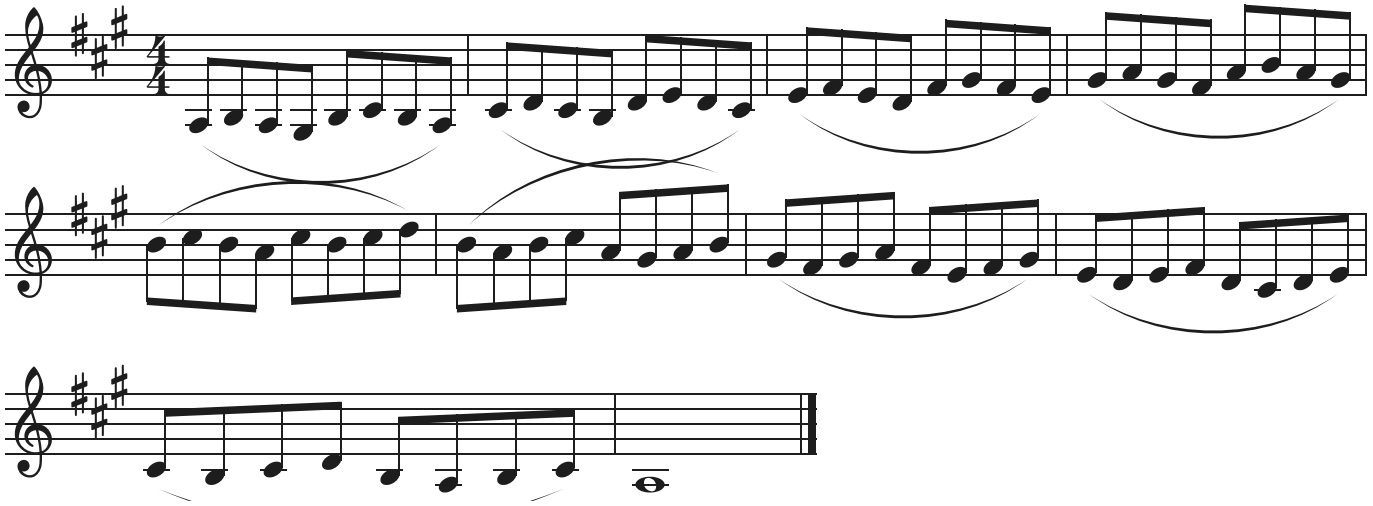
41. Octaves in G major

Low note in the chalumeau or throat, high note in the clarion. Keep the throat open on the top note.



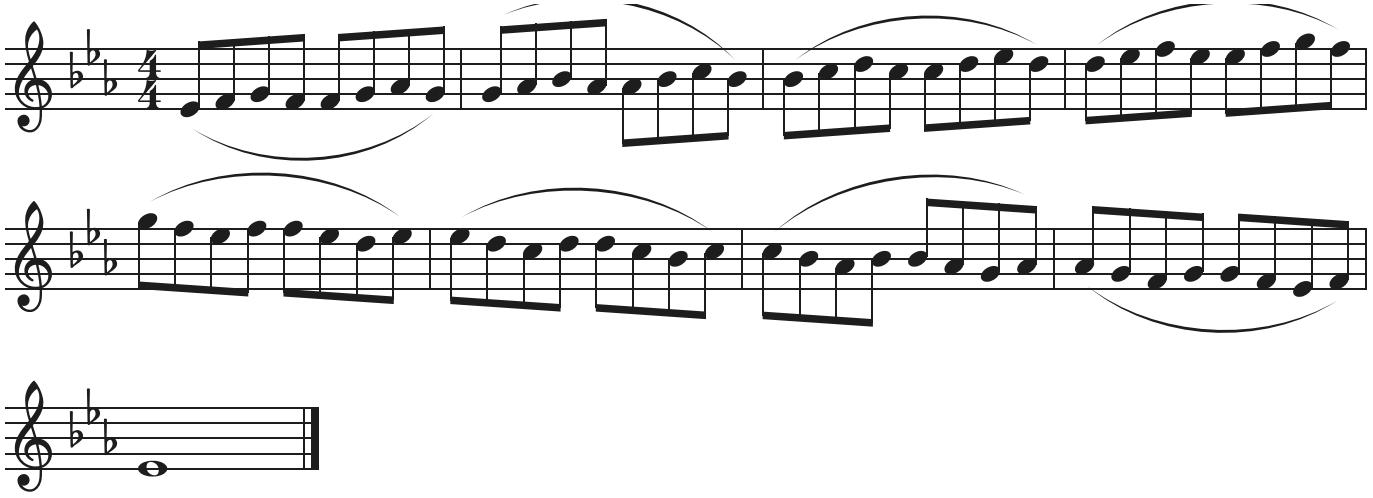
42. Turns in A major

Neighbour-note turns around each scale degree. Ideal for evening out G♯–A–B–C♯.



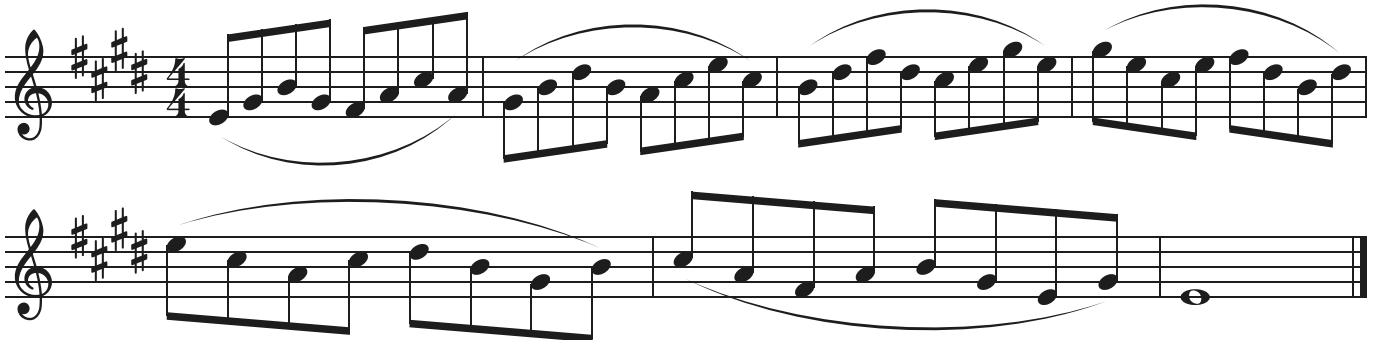
43. Rocking pattern in E♭ major

1-2-3-2 groups. Lots of throat-to-clarion back-and-forth.



44. Broken triads in E major

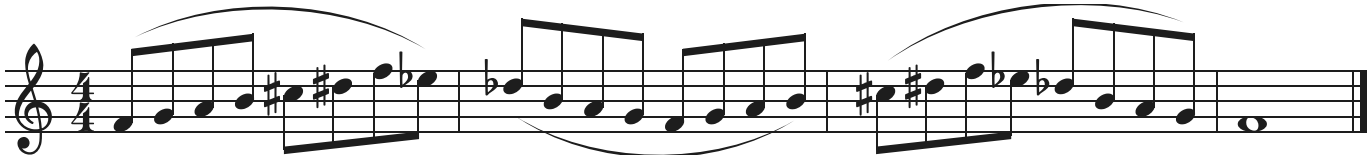
1-3-5-3 shapes. E major puts G♯, A and B right at the break.



VII. Symmetric scales

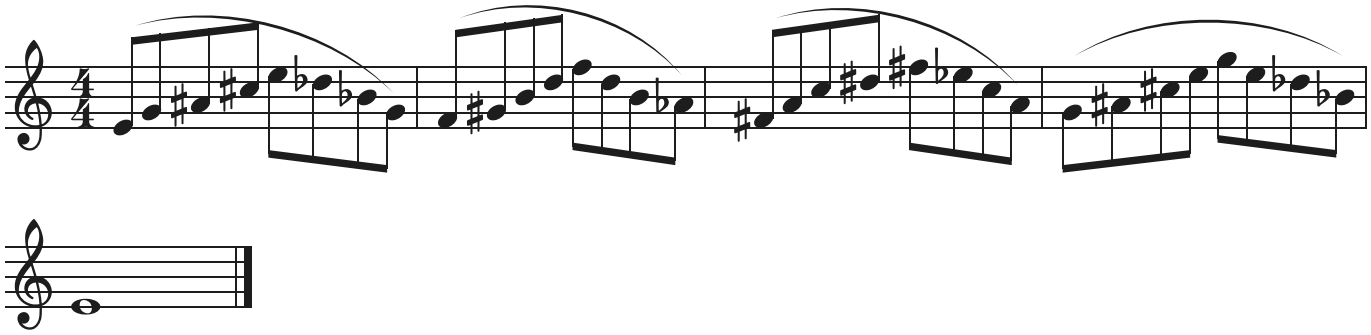
45. Whole-tone scale

Whole steps from F4 to F5 and back, twice. The A–B and B–C♯ steps are the challenge.



46. Diminished arpeggios

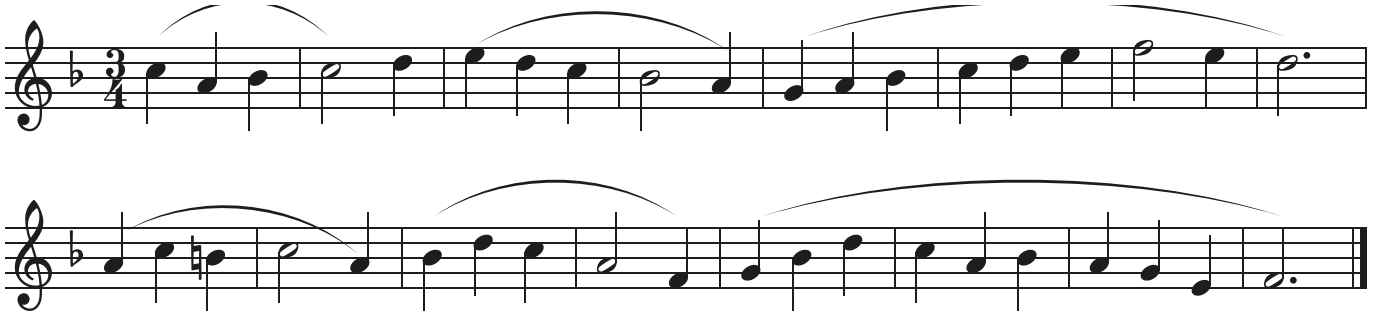
Stacked minor thirds starting on E, F, F♯ and G. Every arpeggio crosses the break.



VIII. Études
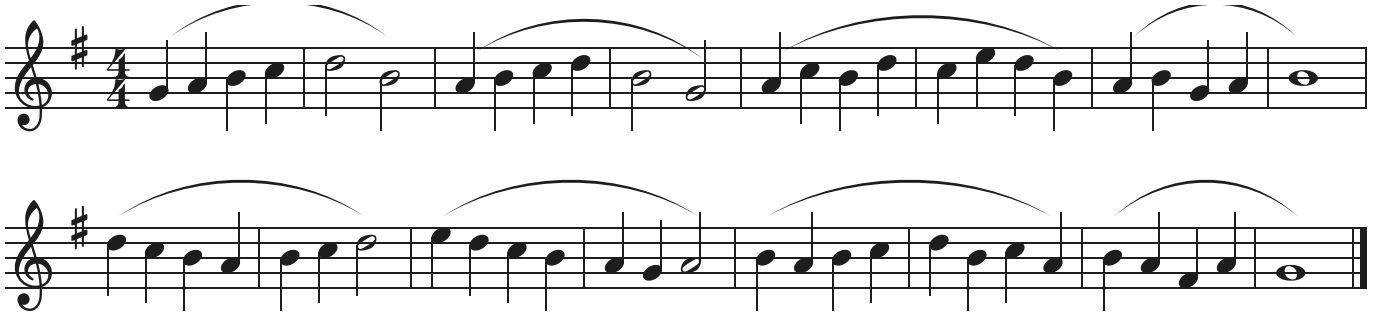
47. Étude 1 — Bridge Waltz

Legato, ♩ = 112. In F major the throat B♭ moves straight to clarion C again and again. Keep the right hand down on every B♭ and A.



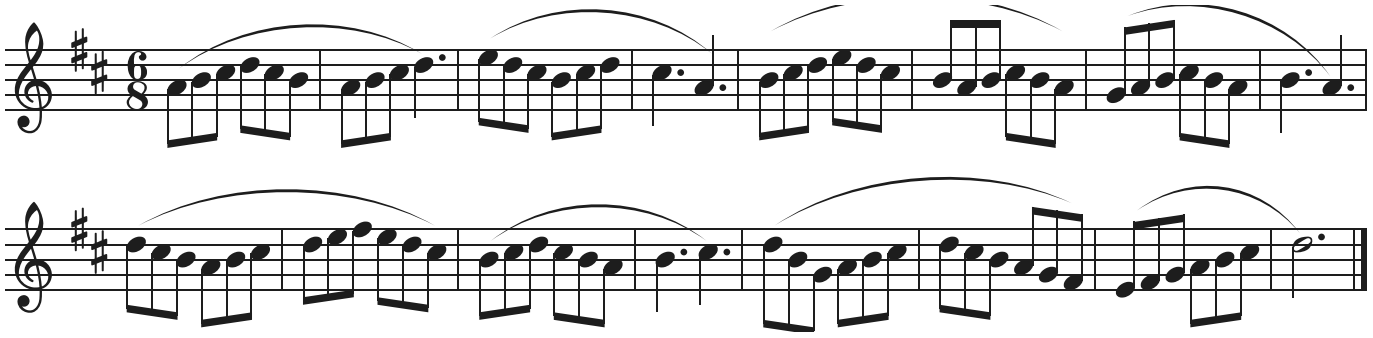
48. Étude 2 — Song over the bridge

Singing tone, ♩ = 72. The melody lives right on the break; make every interval sound like it belongs to one voice.



49. Étude 3 — Running eighths

♩. = 76 → 116. In D major the B–C♯ crossing comes in nearly every bar. Slur two bars, then tongue two bars.



50. Étude 4 — Minor lament

♩ = 66, espressivo. D minor brings the throat B♭ against clarion C♯ — a tricky augmented second across the break.

